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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Monday, January 19, 2026

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[00:00:40] Senate chamber. This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, chamber.

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[00:04:55] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, chamber.

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[00:11:53] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

[00:13:22] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Chamber.

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[00:17:37] The Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate Chamber.

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[00:31:01] Virginia. The Senate will come to order. The senators will please take their seats. Those

[00:33:50] persons not entitled to the privilege of the floor will retire to the gallery. The senators and all in attendance, please stand if you are able and be led in prayer by the Reverend Benjamin P. Campbell from St. Paul's Episcopal Church in Richmond, Virginia. Following the prayer, everyone will please remain standing and be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America by Senate Page Max Davis of Charlottesville.

[00:34:22] Let us pray. Lord, as the senators of the Commonwealth gather together this noontime, we cannot help but be conscious of the history of this chamber, of the privilege and responsibility of democratic government and of the daunting opportunities of this new year.

[00:34:47] We are writing the latest chapter of a journal that began 250 years ago. Meeting in Williamsburg in May of 1776, our forefathers adopted the Virginia Bill of Rights.

[00:35:06] And then, after joining other colonies in the Declaration of Independence, this Senate met for the first time on October 7, 1776. Since then, the Senate has met annually to work for the nurture of our common wealth.

[00:35:26] Today, this chamber includes women as well as men. It represents races and religions from all over the world. In these two and one-half centuries, we abandoned slavery, we proclaimed equality, we embraced diversity.

[00:35:45] Thank you, Lord, for these incredible victories. And now today in this new year, strengthen these senators to continue this ancient work in good faith, to resist oppression in whatever form it may appear, to preserve the fundamental rights and respect the genuine needs of every single person in this Commonwealth.

[00:36:17] Bless our Lieutenant Governor, whose formal leadership begins at this hour. Give energy, insight, and love to every senator in this room. Lift them up, Lord. Help them to be careful, to be compassionate, to be courageous, and to be truthful.

[00:36:44] Amen. I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:37:19] The clerk will call the roll. All those present will vote aye. The clerk will close the roll.

[00:37:36] You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate journal for Friday, January 16, 2026, and for Saturday, January 17, 2026. The senator from Richmond City moves that the reading of the journals be waived.

[00:37:56] The question is, shall the reading of the journals be waived? As many are in favor of the motion, we'll record their votes aye, those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the

senators voted? Does any senator desire to change their vote?

[00:38:15] The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 36, noes 4. Ayes 36, noes 4. The reading of the journals is waived. The clerk will report any communications from the House. We do not have any, Madam President. The Clerk will report any communications from the Governor.

[00:38:34] We do not have any, Madam President. The Clerk will report a communication. Commonwealth of Virginia, Department of Elections, January 14, 2026.

[00:38:49] The Honorable Susan Clark Scharr, Clerk of the Senate of Virginia, State Capitol. Clerk Scharr, on behalf of the State Board of Elections, this is to certify that on January 14, 2026, Upon examination of the official abstracts of votes on file in this office and pursuant to sections 24.2-679 and 24.2-680 of the Code of Virginia,

[00:39:15] It was ascertained and determined that at the special election held on January 6, 2026, Mike J. Jones was duly elected member, Senate of Virginia, 15th District, for an unexpired term ending on January 11, 2028.

[00:39:35] Two certificates of election for member-elect Jones were delivered to your office earlier today, one for your office to keep, and one for you to provide to member-elect Jones. Sincerely, Susan J. Beals, Commissioner. Michael J. Jones took and subscribed the oath prescribed by law on Saturday, January 17, 2026, at 1.27 p.m.

[00:40:03] The oath and certificate of election have been referred to the Committee on Privileges and Elections. The chair now recognizes the senator from Norfolk for the purpose of making a presentation. Thank you, Madam President. It's great to see you there.

[00:40:23] i rise for the purpose of a presentation and introduction the senator has the floor thank you madam president dr michael j jones is a local pastor and is known for his impactful contributions to the community he did write this introduction i'm just saying a virginia native born in portsmouth and as the son of a navy navy seal he was raised in san diego but returned to his family home in Richmond to pursue his calling in seminary. He holds a Bachelor of Arts in

[00:40:57] Sociology from the University of Colorado Boulder, where he was the captain of the Buffalo's 1990 Orange Bowl team. Additionally, he is a graduate of the Samuel D. Witt Proctor School of Theology at virginia union university holding a master of divinity degree and an earned doctorate of ministry from the mccormick theological seminary in chicago illinois in 2005 he founded the village

[00:41:30] of faith a rapidly growing church in the richmond area witnessing his mother's transportation struggles dr jones initiated the cars for christ program gifting over 65 cars to single mothers from diverse religious and cultural backgrounds dr jones ran for city council of richmond in 2015 and served as council president his commitment to equity and opportunity has been a driving force in his public service as he led the fight to remove

[00:42:05] Richmond's Confederate monuments. Prior to joining the Senate, Dr. Jones was previously elected to represent the 77th District in the Virginia House of Delegates. Senator Jones is most proud of his daughter, Jocelyn, a graduate of UNC Chapel Hill, who currently resides in Florida, and his son Jalen, who is currently attending the College of Law at FAMU.

[00:42:33] Senator Jones is committed to fighting for the common good for all Virginia families and is excited to serve in the State Senate. Ladies and gentlemen of the Senate, please join me in welcoming our newest member, the Senator from Richmond City, representing Senate District 15, the Reverend Dr. Senator Michael Jones.

[00:42:58] I thank the senator from Norfolk for that introduction.

[00:43:24] Now comes the time in the morning hour when we have the honor of welcoming our distinguished guests who are here with us today in the Senate gallery. I give my daily reminder of our procedure. A senator will rise and provide the introduction.

[00:43:43] I will then offer the welcome of the Senate, and at the very end we will applaud together. chair recognizes the senior senator from Henrico. Good afternoon, Madam President. Good afternoon.

[00:44:04] Today's a series of introductions. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today's invocation was provided and shared by Reverend Ben Campbell, if I can actually understand.

[00:44:20] He's joining us in the gallery. Reverend Campbell is a long-time Episcopal minister and nationally respected civil rights advocate, a seventh generation of Virginia and author of Richmond's Unhealed History. Reverend Campbell has spent five decades urging the Commonwealth to confront its past while working towards a more just future. As the founder of Richmond Hill,

[00:44:55] a residential christian community and spiritual retreat center his ministry has long centered on reconciliation and reflection his presence at the senate today reflects his deep connection between or the deep connection between faith history and the ongoing work of racial justice in virginia madam president i ask that we give him the warm welcome of the senate thank you i I thank the senior senator from Henrico for that wonderful introduction, and I thank the

[00:45:32] Reverend Benjamin Campbell for joining us and giving us the invocation this morning. Thank you for your words. Thank you for your inspiration. And I ask also that your wife, Annie, please stand and rise. And I ask that we all give the very warm welcome of the Senate to Reverend Ben Campbell and Annie Campbell.

[00:45:54] Thank you. - Thank you. The senior senator from Henrico. - Thank you, Madam President.

[00:46:11] Madam President and members of the Senate, Adam Turk was a beloved actor, personal trainer, and advocate who lived in the city of Richmond. In life, Adam loved all things related to comic books, comic heroes, with a special affinity for Superman.

[00:46:32] He even had the iconic Superman S tattooed on his shoulder. I have it tattooed on my chest. While walking his dog in Richmond on a Saturday morning, Adam encountered a young man threatening a young woman.

[00:46:50] Adam stepped in to de-escalate the situation. He called the police. He kept her in sight. He did everything right. But despite his efforts to de-escalate the situation, the young man pulled out a gun out of his backpack and shot Adam before turning the gun on himself.

[00:47:13] According to the police and the young woman herself, Adam's bravery saved her life. So joining us in the gallery today, I would ask them to stand, are his parents, Peter and Terry Ann.

[00:47:31] Along with several of Adam's friends, I would ask them to stand as well. They're here to advocate for gun violence prevention in Adam's memory. I ask Madam President that we welcome them to the Senate.

[00:47:47] - I thank the senior senator from Henrico, and I want to extend my heartfelt condolences to Adam's family and loved ones and friends who are here in the gallery. I know that Adam's death resonated profoundly throughout the Richmond community as well as throughout the Commonwealth.

[00:48:10] We thank you for your advocacy. We thank you for your courage. And we thank you for joining us today in the Senate gallery. Senators, I ask that we extend the warm welcome of the Senate to the family and friends of Adam Turk.

[00:48:41] - The chair recognizes the senator from Northern Fairfax. - Thank you, Madam President. Good to say that to my former seatmate. I rise for an introduction. - The senator has the floor.

[00:48:56] - Madam President, I would like to extend a very warm and special welcome to a group who is here with us today. We are honoring and welcoming the family of our esteemed new Lieutenant Governor Ghazala Hashmi, Virginia's second gentleman, Azhar Rafiq, and their daughter, Yasmeen.

[00:49:17] Please stand. Thank you for being with us on this momentous day as we honor your wife and mother and start our Commonwealth's new Lieutenant Governor's time presiding over the body. And I ask my colleagues to give your family a very warm Senate welcome.

[00:49:37] - I thank the Senator for the gracious introduction. Senators please join me in welcoming the second gentleman in Yasmeen Rafiq to the gallery. The chair recognizes the senator from Portsmouth. Thank you Madam President. Madam President I rise

[00:50:14] for the purpose of an introduction. The senator may proceed. Madam President I am very proud to announce that with us in the Senate gallery today is Virginia's 49th Attorney General Jay Jones. attorney general jones is accompanied by members of his senior staff including chief deputy attorney general travis hill chief of staff nikki zamasty and legislative director sadie kawakawa gula this past saturday when he took the oath of office attorney general jones made history as virginia's first black attorney general

[00:50:54] immediately after being sworn in he got right to work delivering on the campaign promises announcing sweeping actions to defend Virginia's rights, lower costs, and keep our Commonwealth safe. Madam President, it is indeed a new day in the Commonwealth, and I am proud to stand with leaders who put Virginia first.

[00:51:14] Will you please join me and give my good friend, Attorney General Jay Jones, and his team a warm Senate welcome. That's a reminder of our procedure. I thank the Senator.

[00:51:35] I appreciate the enthusiasm. I thank the senator from Portsmouth for the very gracious introduction, and I extend the welcome of the Senate to our new Attorney General, Gerald J. Jones, and his staff.

[00:51:53] Thank you for joining us. I ask that -- please stand. And I ask that the Senate give the warm welcome to our distinguished guests this morning.

[00:52:17] The chair recognizes the senator from Hanover. The chair recognizes the senator from Franklin County. Thank you, Madam President, and good morning to you.

[00:52:32] Good morning. Madam President, I rise for the purpose of two introductions. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. I had one introduction, but I just got past the senator from Hanover's introduction, so I'm now taking the reins from him. And the reason why is because it will be obvious when I introduce that we have some really good folks young people in the gallery today who were once not just in the gallery they were down here as our Senate pages various classes return on this Monday every year it's kind of a thing if you're a page now this is what you'll be doing next year but I think you know I had the opportunity to see

[00:53:10] them once again and madam president they are growing they're all taller than me which is not saying a lot they've grown so much from their experience here with Madam Clerk's program, which is top of the line, bar none, the best page program there is in the nation, and it shows, and it shows. I was lucky enough to have a couple of my children go through the page program, change their lives tremendously, and it has changed their lives here today.

[00:53:38] And you know, once you're a page, you're always a page, and some of the best friends you're ever going to make are the page friends you make when you sit here in this chamber, and it's obvious, and they all come together. So I don't have all of their names, but we're certainly welcoming the senate page class of 2025 uh probably led by reagan mcdougall wouldn't you say reagan reagan it's ditty you know and but reagan is is she has grown up so much in fact i sent him a picture when you and i were in northern virginia one time and she was just she was standing on a

[00:54:13] table and she was like two and a half feet tall it's amazing how quick they grow and now she is taller than me which is not saying a lot but madam president if you would extend to these young men and women who have come back here to the Senate chamber today the warm welcome of the Senate I would most appreciate it. I thank the senator from Franklin County for that introduction and looking at Reagan's face I think you sufficiently embarrassed her as you were making that introduction but I welcome all of our returning pages we are so proud of the work that you did

[00:54:50] when you were with us and we're extremely extremely proud of the work that you continue to do and the ways in which you grow Senate senators I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our distinguished returning class of pages the senator from Franklin County thank you madam president and I must say Reagan McDougal proves that you can be brilliant smart and still have the last

[00:55:30] name McDougal right he's my seat what can I say madam president I rise for a second introduction up we have some really more brilliant young men and women the senator may proceed thank you who are gracing us with their presence but you probably would remember these young children and especially the organization organizations that they represent these are the robotics teams that come and have come and advocated for legislation that I have put forth they come up with ideas they call me up they ask me to carry it and then I look smart and they come and advocate for us for this piece of legislation especially

[00:56:08] when we're allowing children that are at or below the poverty level or in urban or rural schools and may not have the financial resources to start their own robotics team. Robotics and STEMC is so important for creating that tech talent pipeline for the children, the next generation. And as I've always said from the floor here, our children are our greatest natural resource here in the Commonwealth of Virginia, and they certainly prove it.

[00:56:32] So, Madam President, if you would extend the warm welcome to the following teams and people: Henrico County Team 1086, the Blue Cheese Robotics, Sujay Suribolta, and Schlock Joshi and Ryan Dewan. Loudoun County Team 5338 ACL Robo Loco.

[00:56:49] Niamh Shah, Julia Miller, Coach Leah Steinborn. They hand wrote this so I can't read. Mentor Neil Tawney. Loudoun County Team 11318 Freedom Robotics. Ryan Wang and Menon Jayani.

[00:57:07] And member Arjun, and I apologize 'cause it's handwritten, Tamaju. Henrico Team 540 Talons. Sanvi Sambingi. and christine edassery henrico team 10224 the mav mechanics james gray and jomana morkas and the henrico team 8630 sparky jr vident rothy and elsa mokawa you are going to see these young men and women coming to your office advocating for the bill that they have asked me to carry that they came up with it's a great idea i hope you support them but please madam president if you would extend to this wonderful group the warmest welcome of the senate i would most appreciate it

[00:57:45] thank you i thank the senator from franklin county for that introduction and if you will please stand i believe they may not be yet in the gallery but uh we will certainly provide i am not saying their names again madam president we will provide the warm uh welcome when they arrive but thank you for that introduction the chair calls on the senior senator from prince william thank you - Thank you, Madam President.

[00:58:18] Rives for the purpose of an introduction. - The Senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. I'm honored to introduce three outstanding young leaders who are joining us from Prince William County today who are participating in our youth leadership program this session and joining us in the gallery today are Japlene Gill, a junior at Forest Park High School, Autumn Brown, a senior from Hilton High School and Benjamin Wolford, a junior also from Hilton High School.

[00:58:42] These exceptional students represent the bright future of our Commonwealth and through this program, They're gaining first-hand experience in our legislative process, both in committee and engaging from leaders across our Commonwealth. So Madam President, please give them the warm welcome of the Senate. I thank the senior senator from Prince William for that introduction.

[00:59:02] And I want to welcome all of our visitors in the gallery today. Thank you so much for joining us. Thank you for your leadership. And I hope you have a memorable day as you visit the Capitol and visit our legislators' offices. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to our guest.

[00:59:30] The chair now calls on the Senator from Central Fairfax. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. Today in the gallery, we have the folks from the Humpke Center. The Humpke Center has spent the last 13 years uplifting Asian Americans in all working class communities in Fairfax County and the region, and is now expanding that impactful work into central virginia while also an advocating at the general assembly for economic opportunities

[01:00:04] public safety for all and racial justice through local outreach grassroots organization and civic engagement humke center works to address community current community issues in the short term and and finds long-term policy solution.

[01:00:20] Humpke Center educated 249,948 Asian Americans on their voting rights and options, helped 849 Asian Americans find affordable healthcare, and empowered 563 individuals with citizenship applications while supporting, starting, or growing over 53 small businesses.

[01:00:45] They have done amazing work advocating Asian American communities across Virginia, and I hope it is the will of the body to give them the warm welcome of the Senate. I thank the Senator from Central Fairfax for that introduction, and thank you so much for joining us today in the Senate gallery.

[01:01:05] Warm welcome to the distinguished members of the Hamke Center. Thank you for the work that you do, and I hope you have a memorable visit, not just to our Capitol building, but to the legislators' offices whom you are speaking with today. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the visitors from the Hamke Center. The chair now recognizes the Senator from Eastern Prince William. Thank you, Madam Speaker.

[01:01:40] Madam Speaker, I rise today. I'm sorry, Madam, Madam President. I'm sorry. Madam President, I rise today for an introduction. The Senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. I would like to introduce introduce the six extraordinary high school students taking part in my sixth annual Ella Baker Youth Leadership Program. This year we have students from both Prince William and Fairfax counties representing three different schools including Freedom High School, James Robinson Junior Secondary School, and Christ Chapel Academy. You will likely see many of these incredible students around the Capitol today and tomorrow sitting in on committee hearings, listening to presentations from

[01:02:19] advocacy groups, and meeting with leaders and staff that engage with the legislative process on a daily basis since 2018 my first year serving in the House of Delegates I have sponsored this program with the goal of empowering students of all backgrounds from across my district to get involved in the political process I am proud to continue this tradition representing the 33rd Senate district Ella Baker was a prominent civil rights leader from the Commonwealth of Virginia Miss Baker spent her life fighting to empower disadvantaged groups and played a key role in the most influential civil rights groups at the time including Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s Southern Christian

[01:02:55] Leadership Conference and was eventually named the highest-ranking woman in the NAACP as the director of branches. Ms. Baker is credited for establishing the Student Nonviolent Coordination Committee which helped emerging student activists organize nonviolent protests across the nation. In her honor we hope to empower students across Prince William and Fairfax counties to raise our hands to be leaders in tackling the problems facing their communities. For that reason, please join me in welcoming the 2026 class of Eller Baker Young Leaders to the Capitol.

[01:03:27] I thank the senator from eastern Prince William County for that warm welcome, and I ask if you're in the gallery to please rise. Thank you so much. Thank you for joining us today in the Senate. I hope that you have a wonderful visit as you tour the Capitol building, as you meet with legislators, and as you continue to work with our senator on developing those critical leadership skills.

[01:03:52] Thank you for being here. I ask that the senators give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Ella Baker Youth Leadership Program visitors. The chair now recognizes the senator from Western Fairfax. Good afternoon, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. The senator has the floor. Thank you, Madam President. This afternoon we are joined in the gallery by my friends from the Fairfax County Federation of Teachers.

[01:04:30] Hopefully they're up there. FCFT represents educators and school workers who show up every single day for our students, families, and communities. FCFT is a strong and collaborative voice for public education, for workers' rights and dignity, and above all, for the success of our students in Fairfax County.

[01:04:53] I deeply appreciate their commitment to our community and our teachers and students and their work with me. And I hope everyone will join me in giving them a warm welcome. - I thank the Senator from Western Fairfax for that introduction.

[01:05:09] And I look like you're all standing. So welcome to the Senate. Thank you so much for joining us today in the Senate gallery. I hope that as you speak and visit with our legislators, you have an opportunity to share the tremendous work that you are doing for our students and for our schools.

[01:05:28] So thank you very much for being here. Senators, please join me in providing the warm welcome of the Senate to our visitors. The chair now recognizes the Senator from Western, Prince William.

[01:05:47] - Thank you, Madam President, Madam President. I write for the purpose of an introduction. - The Senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, joining us in the gallery today is my Mayor from Manassas Park, Lana Mensing, along with Council Member Stacey Seierling and City Manager Carl Cole. They are here learning about our General Assembly and advocating for the needs of Manassas Park residents.

[01:06:09] So I hope it is the will of the body to give them a warm welcome. - I thank the Senator from Western, Prince William, and thank you so much for joining us, Mayor, Council Member, and City Manager. Thank you for visiting the Senate Gallery, and I hope that you have productive conversations as you visit our offices today.

[01:06:34] Senators, I ask that we provide the warm welcome of the Senate to our distinguished guests. The chair now recognizes the senator from Richmond City.

[01:06:54] - Madam President, arise for the purpose of an introduction. - The senator has the floor. - Madam President, today we have in the gallery with us the men of Cap Alpha Psi Fraternity Incorporated. I would ask that they would stand. Cap Alpha Psi is a historically African-American fraternity in its 11th year, founded January 5th, 1911, on the campus of Indiana University in Bloomington, Indiana.

[01:07:19] The fraternity has 250,000 members with over 700 collegiate and alumni chapters located in the United States and abroad. Cap Alpha Psi fraternity sponsors programs providing community service, social welfare, academic scholarship, civil rights, education, and mentorship here in the Commonwealth of Virginia and throughout the world.

[01:07:43] Today, they are having their 17th annual John T. Lanier Senior Kappa Alpha Psi Virginia Legislative Day, and the third annual A. Donald McEachin Luncheon. Please join me in welcoming them, and I hope it is the will of the body to give my frat brothers a warm Senate welcome.

[01:08:03] - I thank the senator from the city of Richmond, And I thank you for visiting us today. Thank you for joining us in the gallery. And thank you for speaking to your legislators as you visit our offices. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Kappa Alpha Psi Fraternity Incorporated.

[01:08:33] The chair recognizes the senator from Lynchburg. - Thank you, Madam President. I rise for the purposes of an introduction. - The senator has the floor. - Thank you, Madam President. Today, visiting us in the gallery, we have members of the Virginia High School Republican Federation of Virginia with their chairman, Kellen Habalabi, who has, I've had the privilege of working with Kellen for the past eight

months as I was the Republican chairman of the Republican Party of Virginia, a post which I most sadly no longer hold.

[01:09:12] Kellen represented the high school Republicans that entire time and was a great individual to work with. These individuals are committed to following the principles of a Republican creed involving limited government, individual liberty, and constitutional responsibility. Across the Commonwealth, these students volunteer in their communities, organize issue forums, support campaigns, and actively participate in the democratic process. I will ask you to please join me in welcoming these hard-working high school Republicans to the Senate of

[01:09:50] Virginia. I thank the senator from Lynchburg for that introduction and thank you so much to the Virginia high school Republicans for joining us today for advocating on so many issues and for visiting our legislators in their offices. Senators, I ask that we give the warm welcome of the Senate to the Virginia high school

[01:10:12] Republicans. The chair now calls upon the senator from Richmond City. Madam President, I request unanimous consent to introduce a bill. The senator has the floor. Madam President, I request unanimous consent to introduce a few bills that are after the cutoff date.

[01:10:52] yeah blame the new guy um relating first relating to uh virginia youth empowerment and mentoring grant fund and programming would you like me to read all three and then yes please read read all of the bills that you are presenting the second one is for breakthrough strategies and the use of psilocybin for veterans that are wrestling with mental health faculties

[01:11:21] and the third is relating to a solar strategy fund that would enhance and encourage solar use in the commonwealth thank you senator the question is shall the senate grant consent to introduce three bills relating to youth empowerment breakthrough therapies for our veterans and solar strategies. All in favor of the motion, we'll say aye. Those opposed, no.

[01:12:02] I think the ayes have it. The consent of the Senate is granted to introduce the three bills. Thank you, Senator. Seeing no further introductions for the morning hour, I understand that we are now joined by Senator from Franklin County's robotics teams who have joined us in the gallery if you will please stand senator from franklin county do you wish to repeat

[01:12:41] your introduction madam president thank you only that i will say by the team names henrico county team 1086 blue cheese robotics they got sweet hats you got your hats today there you go um louden county team 5338 acl roboloko louden county team 11 318 freedom robotics the henrico county Team 540 Talon Henrico County Team 10224 the Mav Mechanics and the Henrico County Team 8630 Sparky Juniors. We've all said your names earlier but we're glad you finally made it in here so it

[01:13:19] didn't look like I was making it up that I was your friend. Okay so thank you so I'd ask that you extend to these young men and women really brilliant young men and women the warmest welcome of the Senate. Thank you. I thank the senator from Franklin County for sharing that introduction again, and I can assure you he did say each of your names and properly recognize you.

[01:13:39] We are just so delighted that you are joining us in the gallery. We know your commitment to the work that you do and the excellence that you bring in pursuit of robotics. Senators, I ask that we now extend the warm welcome of the Senate to these various robotics teams. Thank you. Seeing no further

introductions on the floor, resolutions, petitions and bills are now in order the chair now recognizes the senator from hampton for the

[01:14:18] purposes of presenting the committee nominations report thank you madam president i request that the committee nominations report on the senate standing committees be taken up the clerk will read the report 2026 senate standing committees january the 19th 2026 agriculture conservation and Natural Resources: Senator Marsden, Chair, Obenshain, Stewart, Stanley, Suterlein, Hackworth, Williams-Graves, Perry, Pekarski, French, Saleem, Mulcahy, Rome, Senevason, and Jones.

[01:14:58] Privileges and Elections: Senator Rouse, Chair, Deeds, Eben, Hackworth, Deestuff, Carol Foy, Durant, Perry, Diggs, Saleem, Molkai, Senevasin, Cyphers, Jordan, and Jones.

[01:15:16] Rehabilitation and Social Services: Van Valkenburg Chair, McDougall, Reeves, Vavola, Cerevelle, Deestuff, Head, Jordan, Williams Graves, Carol Foy, French, Saleem, Peake, Rome, and Jones.

[01:15:37] Transportation. Bagby Chair, Marsden, Deestuff, Suterlein, Boisco, Hackworth, Sturdivant, Aird, Rome, Diggs, Bukarski, Molkai, Senevasin, Cyphers, and Jones.

[01:15:55] Rules, Locke, Chair, Lucas, Deeds, Marsden, Favola, Eben, McPike, Cereville, Rouse, Bagby, Van Valkenburg, McDougal, Stewart, Killian, and Craig.

[01:16:14] The chair recognizes the senator from Hampton. Thank you, Madam President. I move that the committee nominations report be adopted. The question is, shall the report be adopted? All in favor of the adoption of the report will record their votes aye.

[01:16:33] Those opposed no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted? Do any senators desire to change their vote? The clerk will close the roll. Ayes 40, no zero.

[01:16:51] Ayes 40, no zero. The committee nominations report is adopted. The clerk will now call the calendar. Senate calendar from Monday, January 19, 2026.

[01:17:07] Uncontested calendar, Senate bill on first reading. Senate bill 95. The chair recognizes, oh, I'm sorry, I was blinded by that suit. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax.

[01:17:28] Smiles, everyone, smiles. It's Mr. Rourke. Anybody remember Mr. Rourke? Madam President, I'm glad to be the victim of your first joke of the day. Thank you. uh madam president i'm good to see you up there thank you uh i move that all the senate bills on first reading on the uncontested and regular calendars pages one through two senate bills 95 to 81 that the rules be suspended in the first constitutional reading the titles be dispensed with the question is shall the rules be suspended in the first constitutional reading of the titles

[01:18:02] of the senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars pages one through two senate bill 95 through senate bill 81 be dispensed with all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted do any senators desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll ayes 40 no zero ayes 40 no zero the reading of the titles is dispensed with the chair recognizes the senator from eastern fairfax

[01:18:42] I move that all those bills be passed by for the day. The question is, shall the Senate bills on the uncontested and regular calendars now on second reading be passed by for the day? All in favor of the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no.

[01:18:58] The ayes have it. The bills will go by for the day. The chair recognizes the senator from Eastern Fairfax. Inquiry of the clerk. Does that complete today's very short calendar? Yes, sir. Excellent.

[01:19:13] Is there any other business to come before the Senate? The clerk will report any announcements on the desk. Today, Monday, January 19th, the Committee on Commerce and Labor will meet 15 minutes after adjournment, Senate Room A, GAB.

[01:19:37] The Northern Virginia Delegation Caucus will meet at 5 p.m. in House Room 1000 on the 10th floor, GAB. Tomorrow, Tuesday, January 20th, the Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on General Government will meet at 7.30 a.m. in Senate Finance and Appropriations Room 13th Floor, GAB.

[01:19:59] The Finance and Appropriations Subcommittee on Resources will meet at 8.30 a.m. in Senate Room A, GAB. The Committee on Finance and Appropriations will meet at 9.30 a.m. in Senate Room A, GAB.

[01:20:15] This is a time change. Finance and Appropriations, 9 a.m., Senate Room A. The Agriculture, Conservation, and Natural Resources Subcommittee on Companion Animals will meet at 9.30 a.m. in Senate Room C, GAB.

[01:20:34] The Democratic Caucus will meet at 11.15 a.m. in Senate Room 1 in the Capitol. The Republican Caucus will meet at 11.30 a.m. in Senate Room 2 of the Capitol. The chair recognizes the senator from eastern Fairfax County.

[01:20:57] Would you like to move for a recess, senator? Okay, sorry, I'm not paying attention. Thank you, Madam President. I would move that we stand in recess until 3.30 so we can come back for our joint assembly to hear from our new governor, Her Excellency.

[01:21:16] The question is, shall the Senate stand in recess until 3.30 p.m. today? As many as are in favor of the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to.

[01:21:32] The Senate stands now in recess until 3.30 p.m. today.

[04:08:32] The Senate will come to order. The senators will take their seats. Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. The hour having arrived for the Joint Assembly to receive the governor, the senators will rise and proceed to the hall of the House of Delegates accompanied by the president of the Senate and the clerk of the Senate.

[04:08:56] And upon adjournment of the Joint Assembly, the Senators will return to the Senate chamber.

[04:09:12] Save my stuff.

[04:10:56] - House will come to order. Sergeant at Arms. - Mr. Speaker, the Senate of Virginia. - The members of the House will rise

[04:11:04] and receive the Senate of Virginia.

[04:12:12] The joint assembly will come to order. The clerk of the Senate will call the roll of the Senate. - Senator Ayrd, Senator Bagby, Senator Boisco, Senator Carol Foy, Senator Cyphers, Senator Craig, Senator Deeds, Senator Deesteph, Senator Diggs,

[04:12:44] Senator Durant, Senator Eben, Senator Favola, Senator French, Senator Hackworth, Senator Head, Senator Jones, Senator Jordan, Senator Locke, Senator Lucas, Senator Marsden, Senator McDougal,

Senator McPike, Senator Mulcahy, Senator Obenshain, Senator Peake, Senator Bukarski,

[04:13:14] Senator Perry, Senator Pillian, Senator Reeves, Senator Roan, Senator Rouse, Senator Salim, Senator Cindy Vassin, Senator Stanley, Senator Stewart, Senator Sturdivant, Senator Suterlein, Senator Cerevelle, Senator Van Valkenburg, Senator Williams-Graves.

[04:13:46] You have a quorum, Madam President. Mr. President, whatever. Sergeant Enorms, get her out of here. No, I'm joking. The members of the House will indicate their presence on the electronic voting board.

[04:14:18] The clerk will close the roll.

[04:14:44] Mr. President, a quorum is present. The clerk will report a resolution. Resolution of the Joint Assembly, notifying the governor of organization. Resolve the president of the Joint Assembly appointed committee of ten, composed of six delegates, four senators to notify the governor that the Joint Assembly is duly organized and will be pleased to receive her and any communication she may desire to make.

[04:15:03] As many as favor adoption of the resolution will say aye. Those opposed will say no. The resolution is agreed to. The clerk will announce the committee to notify the governor that the General Assembly is ready to receive her and hear any remarks she wishes to make. Mr. President appoints the following members to notify the governor and escort her to the Joint Assembly.

[04:15:20] Delegates Herring, Tran, Torian, Watts, Kilgore, and Kent, as well as Senators Lucas, Locke, Cerevelle, and McDougald. The Joint Assembly will be at ease.

[04:18:22] Mr. President, entering from the gallery, the first gentleman of the Commonwealth and his party. The Joint Assembly will receive the First Gentleman of the Commonwealth and his party.

[04:19:01] Sergeant in Arms.

[04:19:32] Mr. President, the Governor's Cabinet and other Executive Branch Officials. The Joint Assembly will receive the Governor's Cabinet and other Executive Branch Officials.

[04:20:07] Sergeant in Arms.

[04:20:30] Mr. President, the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission. The Joint Assembly will receive the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission. Sergeant in Arms.

[04:20:54] Mr. President, the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court. The Joint Assembly will receive the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court. Sergeant at Arms.

[04:21:27] Mr. President, the Attorney General of Virginia. The Joint Assembly will receive the Attorney General of Virginia.

[04:22:00] Joint Assembly and guests will please be seated. The Joint Assembly will be at ease.

[04:26:41] Joint Assembly will come to order.

[04:29:49] Sergeant at Arms. Mr. President, Her Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia. The members will receive the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[04:29:58] Okay, Joint Assembly and guests, please be seated.

[04:32:33] As Speaker of the House of Delegates and President of the Joint Assembly, it is my pleasure to present to you, Her Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia, the Honorable Abigail Davis Spanberg.

[04:32:46] Mr. Speaker, Madam Lieutenant Governor, Madam President Pro Temp, members of the General

[04:33:39] Assembly, Mr. Attorney General, Justices of the Supreme Court, members of the Cabinet, our clerks, honored guests, and most importantly, our fellow Virginians.

[04:33:55] Two days ago, we celebrated an inauguration, the peaceful transfer of power that has defined Virginia for 250 years. On Saturday afternoon I spoke about the urgent need to unite for a common purpose amid a national moment too often defined by chaos. Our fellow citizens are anxious about the future and today that work, the work of governing and providing stability begins in earnest. Thank you for your time this afternoon. It is an honor to stand before you as the 75th governor.

[04:34:30] And with us today in the gallery is the first First Gentleman. When we met, neither of us could have imagined we'd end up here, but I'm grateful to be taking on this adventure together.

[04:35:07] Adam, thank you for your willingness to serve Virginia in this new role. As you know, the Constitution of Virginia requires the governor to report on the state of the Commonwealth once a year. I've had this job for a little over 48 hours, so bear with me.

[04:35:24] In all seriousness, it is nearly impossible to step into Thomas Jefferson's Capitol and not feel the weight of our shared history. Generations of Virginians have stood in this building, have shaped the course of our commonwealth and written the history of America, and this week we added new chapters to that history.

[04:35:46] Just yesterday, Chief Justice Cleopal, the first African-American woman to lead the Supreme Court of Virginia in our Commonwealth's history, swore in new members of our cabinet. Our fellow Virginians are also now served by two other history-making public servants, Lieutenant Governor Ghazala Hashmi, the first Muslim woman elected to statewide office

[04:36:09] anywhere in the country, as well as Virginia's first elected African-American Attorney General,

[04:36:35] Jay Jones. In the incoming class of delegates seated in this chamber right now, There are a record: 42 women serving in the House of Delegates.

[04:37:03] These milestones belong to all Virginians, no matter our political affiliation.

[04:37:27] They are proof that our representative democracy is exactly that, is becoming truly representative. And this progress is thanks to the voters from every corner of this commonwealth who made their voices heard at the ballot box.

[04:37:43] And the voters sent us here, each and every one of us, and we must never forget that as we embark on the hard work that we have ahead of us. In November, Virginians from across the political spectrum united to build one of the broadest coalitions for change in a generation.

[04:38:00] They sent a clear, allowed and clear message that they want leaders who will work together to deliver results, and I intend to listen to them. People have asked me in recent weeks about the concept of a mandate. your mandate they wonder what the results of november's elections will mean in practice and

here is what i believe virginians did not elect me to pursue a particular ideological agenda nor did they elect me to settle scores or add noise to our politics they did not elect me to grandstand my mandate is simple to get things done for virginia's families virginia

[04:38:40] schools, Virginia businesses, and our communities, period.

[04:39:02] And if I've learned anything from my previous time in elected office, it's that Virginians want a government that works. They want elected leaders who show up, who listen, who work to make their lives a little easier. They want us to address the challenges that are keeping them up at night.

[04:39:19] That is what I pledge to do for the next four years. And I ask all of you in both parties to join me in that endeavor. To the members of the General Assembly, I know what it means to represent your neighbors, to take on the burdens of public scrutiny, to give up time with your family in service to your community.

[04:39:39] It is no small thing. And whatever differences we may have in the days ahead, I respect the service of each and every one of you, the service that you have chosen to give. And this administration is committed to being your partner moving forward.

[04:39:57] When we work together, Virginia will succeed. It is as simple as that. So let me say this very directly. My door is open to every member of this body, Democrat or Republican. I have always believed that no person and no party has a monopoly on good ideas.

[04:40:16] That's why I've built an administration that reflects that belief. A cabinet of talented, experienced leaders ready to work alongside all of us. They are public servants, and I am grateful to them, the entire cabinet and our staff, that they have answered the call to serve in this capacity at this time.

[04:40:36] And to the career public servants serving across our Commonwealth, across state departments and state agencies, thank you for everything you do. Please understand that I want you and expect you to do your very best work.

[04:40:52] And I want you to have the right tools and feel supported as you do it. I want you to know that I am grateful for the expertise and the commitment that you bring to serving the citizens of Virginia.

[04:41:25] And we have several state employees joining us in the gallery today. Please, if you're a state employee serving our commonwealth and our communities, please stand.

[04:41:53] Thank you for your continued service, for the expertise that you bring to your work in our state agencies and departments. And it is my expectation that our cabinet secretaries continue to lead with respect and with a focus, recognizing the strength of skills and experience that you all bring to bear each and every day.

[04:42:14] During my time in Congress, I was ranked as the most bipartisan member from Virginia. I may have mentioned that one or two times along the campaign trail. And my administration intends to govern the same way, to work together, to deliver for the people of Virginia.

[04:42:31] we must do that in order to tackle the most pressing challenges facing our neighbors today: the high cost of living. I want to take a moment to focus on this because when we talk about affordability, it's important to be clear about what we mean and why it matters. Over the past two years, I've traveled to every corner of the Commonwealth. I've met seniors in Southwest struggling to afford their prescription

medications, parents in Hampton Roads worried about the rising energy bills, young people in Northern Virginia who want to stay and build their lives here in

[04:43:05] the Commonwealth but can't find housing that they can afford. Now I know there are some who want to dismiss these concerns. Some who look at Wall Street and say the economy is doing just fine. Some who simply want struggling families to just be patient. Relief is right around the corner. It's going to get a little bit better. Just wait a little bit longer. There are some who have even called affordability a hoax or a con job and i would invite them to come to virginia and engage with the families and the business leaders that i have met and that i know you all know because the facts tell a different story more than 70 percent of virginians say they can't find housing that

[04:43:45] they can reasonably afford to rent or buy nearly half of college students who graduate from virginia universities leave our Commonwealth within five years. That's above the national average. Prescription drug costs have risen. Energy bills are high. The challenges are real. And my fellow Virginians, this is not a hoax. This is real life. And we cannot be honest. If we cannot be honest about a problem, it will be impossible for us to find solutions to it. The truth is that the prices

[04:44:20] that prices have been rising for years, but the economic uncertainty and the instability coming out of Washington over the past 12 months, particularly for Virginia, have made things undeniably worse, and families are paying the price. So what can we do right here in Richmond to make Virginia more affordable? As governor, I cannot wave a magic wand to make prices drop overnight. Believe me, I wish that I could, but there are tangible steps that we can take right now on a state level to make good on our pledge to Virginia families. On Saturday, some of

[04:44:59] my very first executive actions as governor reflected this mission. Two days ago, I ordered all of my cabinet secretaries and all executive branch agencies to identify where they can reduce costs for Virginians, whether that's immediate fixes or longer-term budgetary, regulatory, or policy changes. They must submit these reports within 90 days because we cannot afford to wait.

[04:45:27] I look forward to reviewing the recommendations and putting them into action. I have also directed a comprehensive multi-agency review of regulations and permitting practices that impact our ability

[04:46:00] to build new homes. We need to cut red tape. We need to cut red tape, eliminate burdensome requirements and streamline approvals. We need to get ready to build more housing. And that's why I

[04:46:28] am establishing a commission on unlocking housing production. And when it comes to the cost of health care, we are not waiting around. My administration is establishing a new interagency Health Financing Task Force. We need to make sure we're spending our health care dollars effectively, we need to strengthen our health care infrastructure, and we

[04:47:07] need to identify where federal cuts will hurt Virginia the most. This task force will be entrusted with finding these answers and it will get to work immediately. But executive action alone is not enough. To deliver lasting relief we need legislation and that's why today i am asking the general assembly to join me in

[04:47:46] passing our affordable virginia agenda a legislative package designed to be a first step towards lowering costs for virginia families in three critical areas health care housing and energy and i want to

thank the majority leadership here today for partnering with me on unveiling these proposals. But they are not hyper-partisan proposals. They are common-sense solutions.

[04:48:11] And I believe they deserve support from every member of this body, Democrats and Republicans. So let me walk through what we're proposing. First, on health care. No Virginian should have to choose between filling a prescription and paying for groceries. But that is the reality

[04:48:46] for far too many families. So let's start with prescription drugs. Right now, pharmacy benefit managers the middlemen known as pbms are driving up the cost of medications while pocketing the savings for themselves they steer patients away from local pharmacies harming and hurting rural independently owned pharmacies they claw back payments from small businesses and they make it

[04:49:08] harder for virginians to afford the medications they need this has to stop our legis legislation will require that rebates go back to patients not corporate middlemen and this will protect independent pharmacies from predatory practices next the affordable care act marketplace at the

[04:49:47] start of this month we watched as leaders in washington sat on their hands and allowed premiums to skyrocket virginia families simply cannot afford to wait for congress to act so we are going

[04:50:01] to act first. Our proposal will establish targeted premium assistance. That way we can keep coverage more affordable for Virginians who are at most at risk of losing it and also benefit all Virginians

[04:50:36] who buy their insurance. And finally, we need to invest in our healthcare workforce. you cannot see a doctor if there is no doctor to see and too many communities across virginia particularly in rural areas are facing critical shortages of health care providers our legislation will thank you our legislation will strengthen incentive programs to recruit and retain providers where they are needed most so that every Virginian can access quality affordable care

[04:51:14] close to home. Virginians are paying far too much to heat and cool our homes and while we cannot control global energy markets there are things we can do to lower monthly utility bills for Virginia families. We are going to expand energy storage across the Commonwealth. Energy storage

[04:51:53] allows us to capture cheaper power and use it during peak demand when prices are highest. That means savings for families and a more reliable grid for everyone. We're also going to expand programs that help lower-income Virginians make their homes more energy efficient.

[04:52:11] Simple improvements like better insulation and weatherization can save families hundreds and even thousands of dollars per year. Virginia needs to be more energy independent. That means solar, nuclear, and yes, despite what Washington might have one think, it also means offshore wind.

[04:52:49] As we speak, the Federal Interior Department is attempting to halt offshore wind development across the country, including one of the largest infrastructure projects in Virginia history.

[04:53:18] this is an attack not just on our energy, but on private business. And while I was glad to see the court ruling on Friday that temporarily blocked this action by the federal government, we all know that this battle is far from over. This project will create thousands of jobs and generate billions of dollars in economic activity in Hampton Roads. And as governor, I will do everything in my power to make sure that it continues to move forward.

[04:53:51] And if we're talking about energy affordability, let me say here today that the Commonwealth of Virginia is rejoining the Regional Greenhouse Cash Initiative.

[04:54:19] This is about cost savings.

[04:54:41] RGGI generated hundreds of millions of dollars for Virginia, dollars that went directly to flood mitigation, energy efficiency programs and lowering bills for Virginia families who need help most. Withdrawing from Reggie did not lower energy costs.

[04:55:00] We have seen them rise. In fact, of course, the opposite has happened. It just took money out of the pockets of Virginians. And so it is time to fix this mistake. Now the third issue in our affordable Virginia agenda

[04:55:35] housing and this issue is so personal for so many Virginians. Young people who grew up here and want to stay here but cannot find an apartment they can afford. Families who have saved for years but still cannot compete in the housing market. Seniors on fixed incomes watching their rent climb higher every year or unable to downsize because they can't buy something else. We have a

[04:56:02] a housing shortage in virginia and until we address it prices will keep rising so here's what we're going to do first we are going to protect renters right now virginia law gives tenants just five days to respond after a landlord files to terminate their lease five days that's not enough

[04:56:36] time to get your next paycheck let alone find a new place to live our legislation will extend that window to two weeks giving families a fair chance to get that paycheck pay their rent and stay in their homes secondly we are going to give communities more tools to build affordable

[04:57:12] housing not every solution works in every locality what works in arlington probably wouldn't work in acomec our proposal will empower local governments to adopt affordable housing programs that fit their needs because the problem the people closest to the problem are often best positioned to solve it and third we're going to make it easier to finance the construction of housing that virginia families can actually afford our proposal creates a revolving loan fund to support mixed income developments so that builders have the resources that they need to create homes for working

[04:57:51] families not just luxury units healthcare energy housing three areas where virginia families are feeling the squeeze and three areas where we can deliver real relief these are common sense proposals they're not about ideology they're about results and i'm asking every member of

[04:58:26] this general assembly democrat or republican to work together to put these bills on my desk as as soon as possible. Because here's the truth, affordability, it's not just a family budget issue, it's an issue of economic competitiveness.

[04:58:41] When a Virginia college graduate cannot afford to live near their job, they're gonna move to Maryland or Georgia or Texas. And when healthcare costs rise, small businesses face higher expenses and workers have less money to spend out on the economy.

[04:58:56] When a family can't afford childcare, oftentimes a parent drops out of the workforce altogether. If we fail to act on affordability, we risk slower economic growth, lower tax revenue, and declining productivity, consequences that would disadvantage Virginia for decades to come.

[04:59:17] So make no mistake about it, we are competing against 49 other states for the best talent in the United States of America and the businesses that follow that talent. If we do not act, we will lose out in that competition.

[04:59:33] And on my watch as governor, I do not intend to lose. I intend for Virginia to dominate.

[04:59:41] We have some work to do.

[05:00:15] We have some work to do. Recent data indicate that in 2025, Virginia saw more people leave the state than move in. And a few months ago, Virginia lost its number one spot in CNBC's annual top state for business rankings.

[05:00:33] And CNBC was clear about one major factor, federal job cuts that were disproportionately harming Virginia's economy. The chaos coming out of Washington, it's not just bad policy, it's doing real damage to Virginia families and to Virginia businesses.

[05:00:49] They aren't just federal workers, they're Virginians whose livelihoods depended on the stable federal workforce. People working in manufacturing, food service, and contracting. Our economy is also still recovering from the longest federal government shutdown in history, a time when so many of our fellow Virginians were anxious about the possibility of more mass firings and the threat of withheld paychecks.

[05:01:18] On day one, I ordered the creation of Virginia's Economic Resiliency Task Force, which will coordinate our statewide response to federal funding cuts, lost research dollars, tariffs, the ongoing impact of DOGE, and more.

[05:01:33] Among its jobs will be to finally gather a full picture of the economic damage done to our Commonwealth, and then recommend measures that we can take right now to slow down the long-term impacts. That is the responsible thing to do for our Commonwealth.

[05:01:50] To Virginia's federal workers who have been laid off, furloughed, or are simply caught in the political headwinds of the moment, hear me when I say, as your governor, I will direct the full power of the office to support you, support Virginia's economy, and support the federal workforce who call Virginia home.

[05:02:09] That's why our Economic Resiliency Task Force will also focus on expanding job placement and public-private partnerships for displaced federal workers and contractors.

[05:02:42] They're real people facing real challenges, and if some leaders in Washington won't fight for them, leaders in Richmond must. And it's it's not just federal job cuts hurting our economy.

[05:03:10] Current trade policies are doing real harm. And no one is feeling it more than Virginia's farmers and rural communities. Agriculture is Virginia's largest private industry. Our farmers feed our families, steward our land and anchor communities across Virginia.

[05:03:32] They deserve a government that fights for them, not one that makes their lives harder with unpredictable tariffs and chaotic trade wars driving up input costs and eliminating entire markets for their products. Cargo traffic at the Port of Virginia is already down 9%.

[05:03:50] That tells a story of broader struggles for our farmers trying to get their products to market, for our forestry industry, for businesses large and small across the Commonwealth. With that, I have directed our Secretary of Commerce and Trade, Carrie Chenery, and our Secretary of Agriculture and Forestry, Katie Frazier, to work together in a coordinated

[05:04:14] effort to help Virginia's farmers and producers expand their reach domestically and internationally, and to make sure that communities across rural Virginia and all of Virginia can reap the

[05:04:52] benefits of trade. I will always work as governor to maintain a stable, predictable business climate for Virginia's employers, employees, and communities. I will be responsible and a good steward of every tax dollar entrusted to us working to protect our AAA bond rating.

[05:05:11] That is my commitment. CDC has done their national rankings 18 times, and Virginia has been in the top three 11 of those times under governors from both parties.

[05:05:43] When we get the fundamentals right, Virginia wins. Our job now is to put ourselves in a position to reclaim the top spot and to stay there.

[05:06:08] I want to acknowledge Governor Youngkin's meaningful work on economic development, particularly on shovel-ready sites and positioning Virginia for investment. His administration and the Virginia Economic Development Partnership deserve credit.

[05:06:25] And now our task is to build upon the progress and work that has been done.

[05:06:46] That means investing in our workforce. It means expanding apprenticeship and paid internship programs. It means strengthening programs like G3 and Fast Forward that help Virginians earn credentials in high demand fields. It means aligning our community colleges with employer needs and recognizing that right Right now, Virginia invests less per community college student than our neighbors in West Virginia and North Carolina.

[05:07:15] We can do better.

[05:07:32] And it means supporting our veterans as they transition to civilian careers. We have an unmatched tradition of military service here in Virginia. We are home to more than 700,000 veterans, many in the room here today.

[05:07:49] And we are home to some of the most important military installations in the world. The patriotic individuals who currently serve or who have previously served have demonstrated leadership, discipline and a commitment to mission that any employer would want within their workforce.

[05:08:08] Our administration will work to expand apprenticeship programs, will streamline credentialing and ensure that military experience translates to civilian licenses. We will work to connect veterans with employers who both understand their skill set and who truly understand their value.

[05:08:47] I also want to speak about public safety. It's an issue near and dear to my heart. You might know that I come from a law enforcement family. My dad spent his career as a federal agent, and I served as a federal agent and later a CIA case officer. I understand the sacrifices and the risks that those who dedicate their lives to public safety face. And we cannot build a thriving economy without safe communities. But frankly, too many of our law enforcement officers, firefighters, first responders are being priced out of the very communities that they protect and serve. If we are asking someone to risk their life

[05:09:25] for their community, the least we can do is ensure that they can afford to live in it. My administration will support public servants with investments in recruitment, retention,

[05:09:53] training, and the mental health resources that they deserve. And we will work collaboratively with communities to keep every Virginian safe regardless of their zip code. Public safety, workforce development, lowering costs in housing, health care, and energy, these are the building blocks of a thriving economy. So let me address one more economic issue directly, because I think

[05:10:33] businesses of all sizes need clarity, they need predictability, and they need to know the rules will not suddenly change on them. As I said along the campaign trail, I will not repeal Virginia's right to work status.

[05:10:56] But my friends, I want to be really direct about something. Being pro-business and being pro-worker are not mutually exclusive.

[05:11:28] Recent history shows that Virginia's economic success has always come from balancing both. We can support business growth and invest in our workforce. We can attract new companies and protect workers. We can be the best state for business and the best state for working families.

[05:11:46] It is not an either-or proposition. It's just hard to get right, but we will here in the Commonwealth.

[05:11:54] That is why we will create a statewide paid family and medical leave program.

[05:12:33] It's why we'll guarantee paid sick days, increase access to Virginia's child care subsidy program. And yes, at long last, raise our minimum wage to $15 an hour. If you work full-time in Virginia, you should be able to afford to live in Virginia. We can do all of this. We can balance

[05:13:13] these forces. We've done it before. We can do it again. And if we do, Virginia will be the best state for talent in America. Here's the challenge. We cannot achieve these economic goals and attract

[05:13:46] talent if we don't take a hard look at our investments in education. The workforce of tomorrow is sitting in our classrooms today. I am the proud product of Virginia Public Schools.

[05:14:21] My husband Adam and I are the parents of three daughters in Virginia Public Schools. We believe deeply in public education. And as governor, I will work every day to make sure our schools are the best in the United States of America, and it starts with having the

[05:14:58] best teachers. Across the Commonwealth, we are consistently asking our teachers, our educators, to do more with less. And we, Virginia, we are paying our teachers below the national average. If we want to recruit, retain, and support public

[05:15:17] educators we need to pay them more period we also need to focus on getting back to the basics in the classroom last year virginia students ranked 51st in the nation for math recovery dead last behind

[05:15:53] every other state and the district of columbia that is completely unacceptable immediately after becoming governor i signed an executive order to promote academic excellence i have directed the Virginia Department of Education to strengthen our core instructional systems including in reading and

[05:16:31] math and I have ordered the department to expand our efforts in advanced math instruction so that we can get our kids back on track and then help them get ahead and the only way we're going to improve student performance is if parents and educators are partners working together to help

[05:17:06] students succeed. Let me be clear, my administration will not use our students, our parents, or our teachers as political pawns in an ongoing culture war. Working together to achieve better educational outcomes has always been a two-way street.

[05:17:42] Putting parents and teachers against each other won't work, it never has. And on the topic of education, there is one issue that consistently unites Virginians. No matter their political leanings it is the notion that every child deserves to learn without fear gun violence is the number one cause of death for

children and teens in the united states of america the number one cause of death for our children it is a horrifying fact and it is one that should motivate

[05:18:17] every one of us in this chamber to ask what can we do to change that i grew up in a family where responsible gun ownership was the norm. My dad went to work with a gun on his hip every single day. We had guns in the house. My uncle was an avid hunter. As a federal agent myself, I carried a firearm every day as part of my job. I respect the Second Amendment and don't let anyone tell you

[05:18:42] otherwise. I also know that we can take common sense steps to keep our families, our communities,

[05:19:07] are kids and law enforcement safe? Over the last four years, dozens of gun safety bills have been vetoed, many which passed the General Assembly with bipartisan support. This includes legislation that would ban ghost guns, restrict access to firearms for convicted domestic abusers,

[05:19:43] and strengthen red flag laws for those who might be a danger to themselves or others. These are common-sense measures supported by an overwhelming majority of Virginians, the very voters who sent us all here.

[05:20:01] Virginia is ready to make our community safer, and I am ready to sign these bills. Please send them to my desk. A word on higher education.

[05:20:35] Virginia has some of the finest colleges and universities in the world.

[05:20:56] And yet, news story after news story, it's not about their successes. It's about them becoming political battlegrounds. Our students deserve better. Our educators deserve better. Our institutions deserve better. Our economy and our Virginia deserve better. And this ends

[05:21:14] right now. Through executive order, I have directed the Department of Education

[05:21:36] under the leadership of Secretary of Education, Dr. Jeffrey Smith, to work

[05:21:59] alongside the secretary of the commonwealth candy munden king to review and evaluate the process for appointments to our higher education boards of visitors and i will work with this general

[05:22:36] assembly to pursue reforms that prevent any future governor democrat or republican from imposing an ideological agenda on our universities governor i have already and i will continue to to appoint serious mission-driven individuals to serve our boards of visitors,

[05:23:15] people whose allegiance is to the institutions they are serving, not any political agenda.

[05:23:39] On Saturday, I was proud to fill vacancies on the boards of UVA, VMI, and George Mason, and now I entrust those individuals to do right by the universities they are going to serve and the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[05:23:56] And I welcome anyone in the room. If you have additional suggestions for folks to be appointed to boards, I will redirect you to Secretary of the Commonwealth, Candy Munden King.

[05:24:23] Now we have a few amendments on their way to the people of Virginia for final approval at the ballot box. First, the amendment on reproductive freedom. Virginia is now the only state in the South where a woman has the same freedom to make her own health care decisions as she did the day of the fall of Roe v. Wade.

[05:24:49] Let's speak plainly about what's going on. In states with bans on reproductive health care, abortion services, and fertility treatment, women facing medical emergencies are being turned away from hospitals, and some of them have died.

[05:25:06] Virginia will not fall victim to this, and the women of Virginia will not die because their doctors are afraid to provide care.

[05:25:16] I trust Virginia women. I trust Virginia families. I trust Virginia doctors.

[05:25:48] And politicians should not dictate decisions for doctors and their patients. And now this constitutional amendment to protect fundamental reproductive freedom in Virginia will go to the voters, and I know they will support it, too. Next, we have an amendment on marriage equality.

[05:26:07] Marriage equality has been the law of the land in the United States of America for over a decade. And yet, in Virginia's most sacred legal document, our Constitution, it still has discriminatory language from an earlier era.

[05:26:25] It is time to remove it.

[05:26:51] Every citizen of this Commonwealth should rest assured that they can marry the person they love, that their union is recognized and protected equally under the law, and that their family is just as valid as any other, and our Constitution should say the same.

[05:27:25] And we have an amendment on the restoration of voting rights. Virginia is one of only two states that permanently strip voting rights from citizens for certain convictions, leaving the restoration of rights entirely to the discretion of one person.

[05:27:43] the governor. It's a shameful relic of our Jim Crow past, and it is time to change it.

[05:27:51] It's worth noting that governors of both parties have worked on this issue over the last two

[05:28:24] decades, most notably governors Bob McDonnell and Terry McAuliffe. Between the two of them, they restored the rights of tens of thousands of Virginians who served their time, rejoined our communities and deserved the right to participate in the most fundamental act an engaged citizen can take, the right to cast a ballot.

[05:28:48] I thank the General Assembly for passing this constitutional amendment to automatically restore voting rights for Virginians and who have completed their sentences. And so let me say something broader about voting in Virginia.

[05:29:05] Virginia has not always been at the forefront of voting rights. Our history includes poll taxes, literacy tests, and deliberate efforts to keep citizens from the ballot box. But look how far that we have come in the past few years: expanded early voting, no-excuse absentee voting, automatic voter registration, Election Day is a holiday in the state, and we passed the Virginia Voting Rights Act.

[05:29:34] I believe that our democracy is strongest when every eligible citizen can participate. And when our decisions reflect the will of the people. And in that spirit, as we protect reproductive rights, marriage rights, and voting rights, we must be ready to contend with further attacks on our democratic institutions across the country.

[05:29:59] Now, I know the General Assembly just took a step forward in being prepared to respond to what is happening in other states. Virginia's proposed redistricting amendment is a response to what we're

seeing in other states that have taken extreme measures to undermine democratic norms.

[05:30:19] This approach here in Virginia is short-term, highly targeted, and completely dependent on what other states decide to do themselves. And for those who may oppose Virginia's response, I call on you to make your opposition to what is happening in other states clear.

[05:30:37] No mistake, Virginia will be responsive and targeted and only with the will of the people.

[05:31:13] And I trust the voters to get this one right. As you all know, trust is the most important currency that we have in public life. And on that topic, I'd like to say a word about how I intend to work with the federal government over the next four years.

[05:31:31] I believe the governor of Virginia and the president of the United States should have a productive relationship built on mutual trust. We are neighbors after all. And let me say here today that where there are shared priorities, I will actively seek and be ready for partnership.

[05:31:54] I want Virginia to lead the way. But I also have a responsibility to the 8.8 million people who call Virginia home. So when federal actions attack and threaten Virginia jobs, I will not hesitate to push back when federal chaos creates uncertainty for virginia families i will work to provide stability when washington fails to lead with dignity and respect and follow the rule of law virginia will above all else my job as governor is to provide what the federal government too

[05:32:31] often has not predictability steadiness and an unrelenting focus on the people we serve I want to close, we're getting close, I want to close by reflecting on why we are here this

[05:33:09] afternoon, not just in this chamber, but on this day, this day of reflection and service. We gather on a day when Virginians and all Americans honor the legacy of Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. If you'll indulge me, I want to share a story about Dr. King that has stayed with me.

[05:33:28] In January of 1957, Dr. King was just 28 years old when he was helping lead the Montgomery bus boycotts. And one morning, 12 sticks of dynamite were found on his front porch. The fuses had been lit and then smoldered out before they could detonate.

[05:33:46] Authorities believe the segregationists who put them there wanted the evidence to be found, a message of intimidation. The next morning, Dr. King delivered a sermon, and for the first time, he publicly shared a spiritual experience he'd had a year earlier. After a threatening late-night phone call had left him sitting alone at his kitchen table, he said an internal voice in his words, quote, almost coming out of nowhere, told him, stand up for the truth, stand up for righteousness.

[05:34:19] And since that epiphany, he said he can, quote, stand up without fear. Dr. King did not demonize. he did not dehumanize, he fought for his cause while still seeing the humanity in everyone.

[05:34:35] That is the model of leadership we should all strive to follow. Because our collective work, it's not just about policy, it is about our approach to governance. If we are going to tackle the challenges before us, and there are many, we need to work together. My fellow Virginians, I am not naive about the state of our politics in 2026. The temperature has risen in Virginia and across the country, and too often we have seen what happens when rhetoric turns reckless, when

[05:35:10] disagreement hardens into distrust, and when we forget that the people on the other side of an argument are still our neighbors. So let me say this clearly to everyone in this chamber and to everyone watching at home. Threats and intimidation have no place in Virginia.

[05:35:29] Political violence has no place in Virginia against anyone for any reason. Organization, harassment, and the politics of cruelty have no place in our commonwealth.

[05:36:08] We can disagree and we will disagree. That is the nature of democracy. But disagreement need not mean contempt and Virginia can model something different for the rest of the nation not not by pretending that our disagreements do not exist but by proving that they can be navigated with seriousness with respect and with good faith before anything else we are Virginians and we can be an example for the rest of the country and the rest of the world. So in that spirit let me answer the question that I was asked to address today.

[05:36:48] What is the state of our commonwealth? I believe that the state of our commonwealth depends on whether we show up for each other. Not just in this chamber, but in our neighborhoods, our schools, our places of worship, and our communities. It depends on whether we endeavor to find common cause and whether we put the communities we serve ahead of the politics that divide us.

[05:37:12] If we put Virginia first, then I can say with confidence that the state of our commonwealth is and will be stronger, more prosperous, and more united than ever before. But there is work ahead. In November, voters sent us here with a clear message.

[05:37:50] Work together. Deliver results. I heard that message, and I hope you did too. At a time of deep division, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. reminded us to stand up for truth, to stand up for righteousness, and to do so without fear.

[05:38:06] To every member of this General Assembly, let us rise to this moment. Let us stand up for the families who are counting on us. Let us stand up for the future that we can build together. Let us stand up for the Commonwealth that we love. Let's deliver for the people who have sent us here.

[05:38:23] you so very much, Virginia, and thank you to the members of the General Assembly.

[05:38:28] General Assembly will come, no, I'm sorry, the Joint Assembly, all of y'all will come to order,

[05:40:26] back to order. The Senator from Mecklenburg, Senator Mulcahy, oh, she's here. As many as favor the motion will say aye. Aye. Those opposed will say no. The motion is agreed to. The Senator from Richmond City, Senator Jones. As many as favor the motion will say aye. Aye. Those opposed

[05:41:02] No. The motion is agreed to. The Joint Assembly is adjourned. Signing down. I would ask, I would ask, I would ask, I would ask that all House members and guests remain seated as the Senate exits the

[05:41:22] chamber. All House members and guests remain seated as the Senate exits the chamber. The

[05:44:42] Senate will come to order. The chair recognizes the Senator from Hampton. Thank you, Madam President.

[05:45:12] I move that the Senate do now adjourn until 12 noon tomorrow. The question is, shall the Senate adjourn until 12 noon tomorrow. As many as are in favor of the motion will say aye, aye. Any opposed? No. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The senate stands adjourned until 12 noon tomorrow.

[05:46:06] The Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Senate chamber. Be sure to stay connected with live

[05:48:13] sessions, catch up on past meetings, and explore our full archives anytime on the Senate of Virginia's

[05:48:19] YouTube channel, Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia, Chamber.